

deus ex homine

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Summary

When you soak a child in shame, self-hatred becomes a weed so thick that one lifetime is not enough to uproot it. But under the gentle scrutiny of love, it slowly diminishes enough to be pruned and with time, flowers may grow again.

A story of two heavily dysphoric men finding peace in each other's arms. Includes an illustration!

Notes

Please pay attention to the tags! While I don't think this work needs the "Dead Dove: Do Not Eat" tag, it was deemed triggering by some beta readers.

► **Click for additional content warnings**

This work was co-authored by iriascend (story) and zappedbysnow (art). The heroic work of beta-reading was done by [Marudny Robot](#), [clarityhiding](#) and [Karma](#).

Summary was inspired by quotes from "Nanette", a stand-up comedy show by Hannah Gadsby, and "Loneliness: coping with the gap where friends used to be", an article by Olivia Laing.

► **Click for title explanation**

See the end of the work for [more notes](#)

The first thing Jason remembers is an overwhelming, stinging pain. It was as if he was drowning in acid, his flesh slowly sizzling away; or as if he was being burned, *cauterised* even, in a raging fire just as likely to be holy as it was to be haunted. He assumes that it was either Purgatory, or his dip in the Lazarus Pit. His memories of those times are... fuzzy at best. Mostly just empty, with occasional speckles of vague emotions.

(The *last* thing he remembers is the sour taste of ash in his mouth. He often says that *innocence died screaming* when questioned about his last moments, but truth be told, it probably wasn't even a murmur. It's tough to make a sound with lungs full of smoke.)

Despite him being pretty much *catatonic* for a good while, his body seems to somehow know what's happening around him, to take note of the passing days. That's probably why the white streak in his hair doesn't shock him when he finally comes to. After all, it's been there for quite some time when he looks in the mirror with proper recognition for the first time in forever. It's not how he remembers himself from *before*, and it's strange; but so are his significantly wider shoulders, the now-green eyes and the six inches extra in height. It's a reality that, while new, he is somehow *familiar* with.

It's the bleached-pale spot on his chest that comes later — much later — that actually throws him off.

At first, he thinks it's some kind of skin infection. He wears kevlar and leather all the time without being even on *speaking terms* with body lotion. It can't be good for him. He'd expect a rash and reddening or even swelling, not a patch that looks like all the colour peeled off it, but he's not an expert. It doesn't itch or hurt, so he's not very worried. When it doesn't go away on its own, he slaps some over-the-counter salve on it and calls it a day.

Some time later it occurs to him that it *grew*. And that's concerning, of course, but not enough to spur him into action. He's got bigger problems.

Then he spots a whole *new* discoloured patch of skin.

That gets him into a proper state of panic. Getting shot at and cut up to ribbons on the regular is all part of the vigilante gig. But he never signed up for skin cancer. Or liver failure. Or whatever else might show as skin changes like these.

Visiting an actual doctor is difficult when you don't really have an official ID (unless you count the death certificate, that is), but it's not something enough money can't solve. What's harder is to bring himself to let some stranger examine his bare skin and the vulnerability that comes with that — yet, the looming threat of a terrible illness eventually is enough of a push. Together with the doctor, they decide on blood tests and a biopsy of the affected regions to learn what's truly going on. The results come in fast and bearing different news than he expected.

Vitiligo isn't a word Jason had heard before his diagnosis, so he diligently does his research on his newfound condition. Aside from developing fairer patches on his skin (and maybe increasing his risk of getting other assorted diseases), it doesn't really *do* anything and poses

no danger to his health on its own. Yet it still feels like some sort... Well, not quite a *divine punishment* because it's not very dangerous, but even a relatively harmless autoimmune disease kind of suggests that the Lord is trying to take him down a peg.

And it kind of succeeds in doing that. Every so often, when changing clothes or dressing a wound, he has to look at the depigmented patches. And sometimes they even grow or there's a new one. And Jason can't help but be... sad about it. Or maybe angry? *Some* kind of negative emotion, he's not good with naming them. Because those patches are infringing on his sense of self. The white streak of hair that's now his most identifiable feature – he accepted. The growth spurt that he missed – he accepted. The autopsy scar that reminds him about his death – he accepted. They're all his now. They came before he *became anew*, so in a way they've always been a part of *this* Jason. But these patches? These are *new*. They feel like a... a violation of his body. They take away his agenda in *his own life*, change him without his permission. The scars he accrues during missions are at least proof of his accomplishments against all odds, proof that he's still alive and kicking, and doing the Lord's work. His own, fucked up version of stigmata. The patches mean nothing and tell no tale. They're just... mocking him.

That only adds to his list of reasons why he hardly ever takes his clothes off, especially in front of others.

(The other items on the list are parts of his teenage past that he'd very much rather forget about. But it's hard to make your brain stop giving you nightmares, and stop your body from freezing in fear at the mere mention of physical intimacy. Some wounds even the Pit can't heal. The terrifying feeling of the grubby hands of a sleazy bastard on you is one of them.)

Not that he has a lot of reasons to undress publicly anyway. And every time a possible occasion arises, he still finds a reason to keep his clothes on. While he *is* a thespian and loves being the center of attention, he'd rather *not* be examined like a zoo animal. Plus, it would certainly require nothing short of a miracle for people to not make a huge deal out of his disease.

Even the Outlaws are not privy to it. Or maybe *most importantly* the Outlaws? In the best case scenario, Roy might just tease him about it, but Kori would be at the very least quite concerned. Especially when she realises that it's not natural for humans to be spotted like a cow. And while some friendly ribbing and some questions are nothing he couldn't endure, he doesn't trust himself to keep his mouth shut about... everything that's churning in his head in regards to his condition. He knows that if he starts talking, they'll know. They'll know just how weak he is, just how pathetic, just how easy it is to get under his skin (ha!), and that? That's a secret he'll take to his second fucking grave.

So far, it hasn't been an issue. Outlaws don't even *have* showers to share, and the Bats don't often see him without his *helmet* on, let alone without a shirt. In the odd event that he's injured, he makes himself scarce before anyone can try to talk him into letting Alfred have a look.

That starts to change one day, in Vienna of all places.

He's tailing an international gang across Europe when he runs into Red Robin. Jason would ignore him, at most acknowledging Tim in passing with a stilted nod, but Lady Luck isn't having a good day that day and... Well. Tim's *trying* to blend in, but still looks awfully out of place in Austria in his very clearly American attempt at casual wear. In retrospect, it's no surprise he gets jumped on by an opportunistic local gangster. One thing leads to another, they end up fighting with a couple of guys, and Tim gets flung across the street and straight into the Danube by a surprisingly capable goon.

After the kerfuffle ends, Jason offers him a hand to help him out of the channel. It's an unusual display of kindness, but they're in Austria, so *bella gerant alii*¹ and all. Though to balance it out, he adds a mocking quip to it.

In exchange for his sharp wit, he gets yanked down into the water by a frowning Tim. The river isn't very deep, but it's the middle of the night and freezing, so it obviously pisses him off. He should've expected it to happen, though; Tim never takes his snappy remarks well, to nobody's surprise.

He's about to push Tim back into the deep and watch him float downstream like a discarded rubber ducky, but the guy sneezes so hard he almost loses his shoes. That's when Jason belatedly remembers that Tim is immunocompromised. The chance of him catching a nasty flu because of this is quite high. He'd then pass it on to every other Bat and cause Alfred to declare unconditional, mandatory bed rest until they recover. Jason would then have to wrangle Gotham all on his own, which is a pain in the ass he'd rather avoid.

Normally in this kind of situation he'd offer Tim his jacket and call it a day, but this time it's just as wet as Tim's. In another bout of good will, he suggests Tim dries himself in the room Jason's renting nearby. Red Robin operates in an in-and-out manner and doesn't establish local bases unless absolutely necessary, so his only other option is to wait around a couple hours for his remote-control jet to pick him up. Another nuclear sneeze is all that's needed to convince him that going with Jason is a risk worth taking.

And Jason is, for once, sincere. His spot is a cheap AirBnB where the owner knows not to ask questions, but it's got everything they need to get Tim back on his feet: hot tea and local honey, towels and a change of clothes (even if a couple sizes too big for the Pretender).

Once inside, he kicks off his wet shoes, puts the kettle on and— freezes. He knows he needs to take off the soaked clothes as fast as possible. He desperately *wants to* get rid of the wet fabric clinging to his skin and change into something warmer than the midnight Austrian air. But there's a problem in the room preventing him from doing it.

A Tim-shaped problem.

And good will isn't enough for him to come out as a freak to a Bat for the first time.

He looks up, trying to find a good and plausible excuse as to why he might be shy about undressing with someone in the room. It's not something that a vigilante would usually be opposed to, after all — not with the amount of medical emergencies and costume malfunctions most of them had to go through. To his surprise though, Tim seems similarly frozen with anxiety in the middle of taking his shirt off.

There's an awkward beat of silence as they stare each other down with unreadable faces. Then Jason makes a non-committal grunt and heads towards the bathroom without a word. Tim frowns, clearly analysing the situation, but doesn't comment. He tends to be like that, Jason's learned; keeps quiet until he's 100% sure about things, so it's obvious Red Robin's gonna put some effort into investigating him later. He hopes he hasn't given him enough clues to properly figure it out anytime soon.

Either way, that's a problem for future Jason.

He becomes future Jason three months later.

Jason's generally good at managing his issues. He really is. You can count the things that could cause him to have a full-blown panic attack on the fingers of one hand now. You don't even need to use all your fingers to do it anymore! And his nightmares are few and far between now, too!

It's just that Lady Luck *fucking hates him*.

He's been playing the part of a rookie goon for hire so he can infiltrate some of the gangs that didn't opt into Red Hood's mandatory labour union. So instead of doing any of his usual activities — busting rival organisations, or helping people out, or scaring some petty thieves off — he's pushing boxes and barrels around in a random harbour warehouse.

And sure, he's on guard, as always, but he doesn't really expect any trouble. Then there's a loud, deafening *boom* and he realises that somewhere in the building a bomb went off. Normally, it wouldn't be a problem, even if he's not exactly prepared. One blast isn't a threat. But then there's another, and another, *and another*; either on a timer or simply a chain reaction of flames and rubble.

The danger reaches Jason in a matter of seconds, setting off an explosive in the room he's in before he has any time to really process what's happening, let alone *react*. His ears start ringing, the air fills with smoke and clearly toxic fumes, half of the boxes around him set ablaze. The walls begin crumbling and falling apart, and soon enough the ceiling's starting to cave in.

Suddenly all Jason can think of is the sound of a crowbar dragged across the concrete floor, and Joker's menacing giggle. He thought he'd moved past this. He thought he was stronger. Yet all it takes to reduce him back to a terrified, 14-year-old boy is an explosion he didn't expect — an explosion just *a little* too close to him.

With his heart trying to burst out of his chest and his mind in a daze, all he manages to do is brace for impact. As the pain comes, he hopes that at the very least he stays dead this time.

When he comes to, he's neither in Heaven nor in a coffin again, and that confuses him. He ponders that maybe his transgressions finally caught up with him and he ended up in Hell this time, where he'd argue he belongs more readily these days. Still, despite knowing of his

numerous sins, he wishes for salvation that he doesn't deserve. And because only the Saints can save him now, his first instinct is to pray. Maybe they'll take pity on a prodigal son.

"Hail Mary, full of Grace, the Lord is with Thee-

The darkness around him stirs and grumbles, as if seared by the holy words. He perseveres; the valley of the shadow of death does not scare him, because he's been through it before. And he came back singing.

"-blessed art Thou among women-

"Jason?" tempts the darkness. The voice, though sweet, is distant and muffled, so the prayer must be working at keeping the demons at bay.

"-and blessed be the fruit of Your womb-

The darkness stirs again, then shrinks away when a speck of light, barely a single ray, pierces it. Jason groans and squints, blinded by the ardent glow shining in his face. As it grows, chasing away more of the shadows, he can almost make out a figure in it, bright and magnificent. It's as if an Angel came to mercifully lead him from death this time.

"Jay? Can you hear me?"

It takes Jason a moment to react, to blink and rub his eyes and finally focus on the source of the voice. Though he can't make out many details, the man in front of looks familiar, and his voice is... comforting.

He hesitates, still. Devil leads people astray with less, after all.

"Please, we—" the man begins when there's no answer to his beckoning, his tone carrying a sense of urgency.

"Red, can you get on with it?!" another voice reaches them, from somewhere further away. "My back isn't made of steel!"

Jason shakes his head and blinks once more, for a good measure. Finally, things slowly start to get back to him through the haze and headache.

"Jason, we need to get out of here," **Tim** says, offering a helping hand. He's smiling softly, and Jason doesn't even realise how much it eases his nerves.

Jay looks around. He would be embarrassed about his recent... visions, but his mind is more preoccupied with the now-apparent imminent danger. Even though he could *hear* him, he can't see Nightwing at all, only debris — chunks of concrete with rebar sticking out of them, smashed boxes and barrels, all on a carpet of shattered glass. Tim must've heard him, and crawled through the rubble to get to him, while Nightwing makes sure their only exit doesn't collapse. Judging by the pained groans and grunts, he's accomplishing that by sheer force of will at this point. Heaven only knows how long it took Tim to get through to Jason.

He doesn't hesitate any longer and reaches out for the still outstretched hand. The movement brings his forearms into his view; the sleeves of his shirt are barely there, turned to scraps by the blaze and the falling rubble. The vitiligo patches, usually hidden away underneath, are now clear as day, a dozen shades fairer than the rest of him, even despite all the dirt.

He gasps wordlessly, panic setting in once again. He immediately tucks his arms away, trying to hide them. He realises it's no use; all his clothing is ripped and damaged and he's too big, too unwieldy, *too exposed*. He stumbles back, curling in on himself as if that could help, only to hit the wall with his back and cause the rubble around them to creak menacingly.

His breathing speeds up in sync with his heartbeat. Everything is on full display; he can't escape, can't hide how *faulty* he is, how *damaged*, how—

“Red!”

Tim ignores Nightwing once more. He turns away from Jason and reaches behind his neck with one hand, the other still outstretched in a peace offering. The motion is swift and graceful, and done with zero hesitation. He detaches his cape and throws it over Jason.

The sudden weight on his shoulders is enough to startle Jason's mind right back into his body. He blinks, confused, staring at Tim.

“It's okay,” Tim says, unusually gently for his typically no-nonsense attitude. He's pointedly looking to the side and there's softness in that gesture, in the way he leans away and gives Jason space. He makes it look... *easy* to let Jason go at his own pace, to let him retain his dignity. He's effortlessly handling what Jason thought to be a herculean effort and in that dark moment, it again makes him look like a truly Holy creature in Jason's eyes.

Emboldened by Tim's calming presence, he wraps the cape around himself. Having covered his skin and his sins, he feels brave enough to grab onto Tim's hand and stand up.

Red Robin leads him out of the rubble in deliberate silence. With each step, he loses a bit of the aura of divinity that he had in the darkness. When they clamber out and into the light, letting Dick finally let go of the beam he's been holding up, Tim's fully human again.

Still, when Nightwing dives in to hug Jason and check him over, Tim stops him before Jason can even move a muscle, like a guardian Angel.

“He's contaminated.”

Jason's pretty sure there's nothing about him that's more contaminated than either of them. But he ain't gonna object, since it gives him a reason to hold onto the cape, which is the only thing keeping Nightwing from learning his secret.

That and, apparently, Tim's good will.

Ever since then, it's clear that Tim *knows*. He acts as if he doesn't, though; doesn't use the knowledge for anything or tell anyone, doesn't even blackmail Jason with it. It is somehow

worse than if he would.

It annoys Jason – to be at someone’s mercy like that, and to not understand someone’s motives. The irritation builds up over weeks until Jason’s about ready to burst with frustration. Eventually, it’s enough of a thorn in his side that it spurs him into action. He wanders towards the Nest one morning after wrapping up his own business, seeking answers. Or – at the very least – a confrontation, so he can be angry at Tim instead of this feeling of... gratitude? Hope? Fear? He doesn’t know. Either way, he’d rather be angry than whatever the fuck it is that he’s currently experiencing. He’s good at being angry.

He doesn’t quite make it to the apartment. A whole block away from the Nest, RR’s brilliantly red costume catches his eye, standing out like a sore thumb among the shadows of an alleyway. In his usual fashion, Jason approaches the encounter with jaded distrust and hurtful snark.

“Want your cape back, Pretender?” he asks as he lands on a nearby fire escape. Tim’s head snaps up immediately, but instead of a witty response, all Jason gets is a hiss of pain. Only then does he notice Tim is slouched against a wall in exhaustion and his shoulder is conveniently hidden in the shadows. “Oh, someone got you bad, huh?”

Tim just flips him off.

He makes his way down while Tim tries to calm his breathing and hide the sweat pearling on his forehead. Vigilantes — in general, but this hypercompetent fucker even more so — tend to never even *acknowledge* their injuries. They act like they’re fine even when they’re actively bleeding out. For Red to not be able to ignore his suffering...

Jason circles him, examining the situation. He whistles, half in concern, half in amazement, when he finally locates the source of the issue.

A piece of metal is sticking out of the back of the shoulder that Tim is attempting to hide. It’s absolutely filthy, covered in blood, both old and fresh, assorted Gotham grime and flakes of rust.

Tim must’ve fallen onto exposed rebar or had some scaffolding collapse under him in a very, very unfortunate way. It kind of makes Jason feel better about his own shitty luck.

“I’m feeling like doing a good deed,” he says nonchalantly, gesturing vaguely to the metal rod stuck in Tim. “Want me to get that out?”

“I can handle it,” Tim hisses in response. It is a fair reaction; Jason’s help is usually a package deal with relentless mocking, which isn’t something you’re looking forward to when hurting.

“You won’t be able to reach the wound to properly disinfect and stitch it.”

“And?”

“It’s fucking nasty, kid,” he says flatly. “God knows what kind of shit was on that thing. It’s gonna get infected.”

Tim scoffs, but doesn’t try to deny the facts, so Jason continues. “And with your shitty immune system? You’re at death’s door. I bet you already have a fever.”

“What do *you* care?” Tim must be in a really foul mood and in a lot of pain if he’s getting riled up like this. Jason’s kind of enjoying being the controlled one for once. “Scared that scrap metal will do a better job than you? Or just want to have the pleasure all to yourself?”

“Don’t flatter yourself, birdie. Even if you were on my list these days, I am not one of the weirdos hell-bent on *‘being the only one allowed to kill you’*,” Jason says in a mocking tone. He falls silent for a second, then shrugs. “I just think even you deserve a better way to go than sepsis.”

Tim doesn’t reply, just stares at Jason intently for a solid 30 seconds, as if trying to intimidate him into letting go. When he realises it’s not working, he hastily comes up with another argument. “Alfred’s—”

But Jason cuts him off, crossing his arms over his chest. “We both know you’d rather die.” While Jason’s help comes with relentless mocking, Alfred’s help comes with *lectures*, and sensible ones at that. It’s definitely worse than any insult Jason could hurl at Tim.

Weirdly enough, Tim looks away when he responds. “Well, you’re right about *that*, at least.”

It takes Jason a second to understand the gravity of those words. The realisation leaves a terrible, sour taste in his mouth.

He would rather die.

Is Tim really that far off the deep end? Why? What happened? Even in his darkest moments, Jason wasn’t thinking about offing himself. And he is a solid candidate for the “World’s Worst Childhood Trauma” award! What the hell is the Pretender going through? And more importantly, why is he alone in this state? Hasn’t anyone been helping him? Do they even know? Is Bruce really so bad at parenting that he... hasn’t noticed?

He suddenly finds himself wanting, desperately, to say something, *do* something. They aren’t on the best of terms and Jason is the last person who should be trying to comfort him, but... At that moment, Tim is just another guy living in the Gotham underbelly. Just another dude that needs Red Hood’s help.

It’s just that he doesn’t quite know how to — doesn’t really know if he even *should*, given their history — so, instead he shrugs again and says: “What if we leave the clothes on?”

Tim frowns immediately. “What? What is *that* supposed to—”

“You’re not the only one to connect some dots in Vienna, kid.” It’s not *technically* a lie. Jason doesn’t know what Tim’s reasons to avoid showing skin are, because he didn’t care enough to look into it. But the agitated reaction confirms that *something* is going on.

Tim doesn't say anything, like he doesn't want to admit that Jay's got it right. But he's the one that broke the silent agreement to ignore it when he gave Jason his cape, so this one's on him.

"Your shoulder, nothing more," Jason adds, deciding to capitalise on Tim's hesitation. "Hell, not even that. Keep the whole suit on, I can cut an opening around the wound. Just enough to see what I'm doing. No more than an inch of skin. How's that sound?"

Tim, once again, doesn't respond. After a moment of stillness, he slowly starts walking towards the Nest. Jason figures it's as close to an agreement as he's going to get and follows him.

Since then it's... different with Tim. Jason wants to believe it's a two-sided blackmail checkmate, but in reality it's more of a... shared secret. Some sort of mutual understanding. A different kind of Dead Robins Club.

He never thought he'd bond with someone over his abysmal self-esteem and body image issues, but apparently it's a thing. He also never thought he'd bond with *Tim*, of all people.

But he does. And it's not terrible, to his surprise. Sure, it's sad that they both are broken like that, but also reassuring to know you're not the only fucker with that kinda problem. They mostly just share lifehacks and tips every so often — how to deal with wearing long sleeves in the summer heat, the like — and corner the other for judgement-free blind stitches. Sometimes, they talk a bit while at it.

It's mutual understanding, nothing more.

Nothing more, Jason insists, as he starts seeking Tim out during patrol and stopping to talk a bit.

Nothing more, Jason rationalises, when he finds himself looking forward to their chats.

Nothing more, Jason tells himself, when he agrees to work a case with Tim. Then another and another, until it stops being unusual.

Inevitably, they spend the entire night fighting side-by-side during one of those cases. The sunrise catches them with too much adrenaline in their systems to let them sleep anytime soon, and Tim suggests grabbing food together to celebrate a job done well. Jason demands they clean up and change out of costume first. To his surprise, Tim invites him over to the Nest.

It's logical; one of Jason's safehouses would be closer, but the Nest is definitely *cleaner*. Tim probably even has fresh towels and scented soap, while Jason can't even guarantee warm water. Still, it feels weird to be... welcomed.

Tim calls dibs on the shower, and without a second thought, Jason starts rummaging through the kitchen for a snack.

"*Just coworkers*," he whispers adamantly under his breath when he realises he's making breakfast for two instead.

It makes sense to prepare more food, he argues. It's not like it means anything. He's not *catching feelings*. It's just work. Mutual understanding.

It *needs* to be. For Tim's sake, if nothing else. He deserves better.

(He recently asked his confessor about... having *feelings* for men. Just out of curiosity, of course. The priest sighed sadly, and Jason fully expected to be given penance for just having the thought. Instead, he was given a whole pamphlet about queerness. The little booklet had answers to all the questions he had, and to those he didn't know he had, too.)

Tim emerges from the bathroom half an hour later and sniffs the air, intrigued. Recognising the smell of fried garlic, he hops over to the kitchen to check what's cooking.

"You can't possibly intend to eat all of that on your own," he says, looking at the eight whole eggs in the pan.

"Wasn't planning to," Jason mumbles in response, not even sparing Tim a glance, laser-focused on getting the texture of the eggs *just right*. "Grab yourself a fork."

Tim stares at him for a second, then bursts into laughter, so suddenly and abruptly that he gives himself the hiccups. His laugh sounds like... like he genuinely enjoys Jason's presence.

It makes Jason feel like his heart grew three sizes and started singing. At that moment, nothing but Tim's laughter — honest and gleeful and *for him* — matters. The entire world could burn for all he cares.

That realisation paralyses him. The spatula falls out of his stiff hand. Tim looks up at him, confused and concerned, swallowing his now-inopportune chuckle.

"Jason?"

But Jason doesn't answer. He doesn't know what to say, anyway. He can feel the façade of his fabrications fall apart, exposing the raw, vulnerable feelings underneath. And that... that scares him.

He turns to Tim seeking help, looking for something, *anything* that could make him believe his carefully constructed lies again. He hopes that Tim can save him once more, from himself this time. What he gets instead is... a Revelation.

Between the pink blush of Tim's freshly-scrubbed skin and the droplets of moisture still clinging to his damp hair, he's akin to a flower covered in the morning dew. He's dressed in a fresh, white pyjamas, with a blue bathrobe hanging by the hood off his head like a veil. He looks... immaculate. The soft light of the rising sun shines through the window in the back of the room, brilliant and incandescent. It crowns Tim's head with a halo of blindingly bright light, making him look nothing short of divine. It makes Jason feel both like he should crawl

into a dark hole like an unworthy maggot, and piously bask in the exalted radiance at the same time.



[Illustration by zappedbysnow \(ao3\) / snowzapped \(Tumblr\)](#)

His heart tightens with that weird mix of adoration and fear, and he realises. There's no returning now. He can't run anymore, he can't lie any longer. His chest is open and his heart is beating free; he is stripped bare, straight to the core, and the truth is out.

*Tim's **not** just a coworker.*

He's... so much more.

Jason was right, back then in the rubble, to see Tim as divine. His prayers, desperate and deranged, almost sacrilegious, were heard after all. He's but a worm, a wretch, a ghost haunting the earth seeking vengeance and violence. He deserves no Grace. And yet, before him stands salvation. An Angel or a Saint, holiness incarnated.

He falls to his knees, averting his gaze in reverence.

"What's wrong?" Tim asks and reaches out, touches Jason's shoulder, then cheek, then finally grabs his hand in worry. It sends a jolt through Jason as if he is a devil seared by holy water. He feels like he has no right to look at the heavenly transcendence embodied before him, let alone touch those silken, sacred hands.

Tears well in his eyes. "I'm—" he stutters out, voice breaking. "I'm so sorry. Please, forgive me, I—"

Tim smiles again, sadly and softly this time, and guides Jason's head to rest against his lap, gently stroking his hair. Once more, the heroic effort of protecting Jason's dignity, of understanding and soothing him comes to Tim as easy as breathing, as natural as gravity.

"Shhh... I'm here. You're safe." Jason wraps his arms around Tim's legs and torso, afraid he'll disappear if Jason lets go. "Take all the time you need."

Jason cries for a long time, face pressed against Tim's belly, but it brings no deliverance. He cannot escape his feelings. There's no returning to the comfort of deceit once you've faced the Truth. So finally, he finds enough courage, swallows a hiccup and after a moment of silence, whispers:

"I... love you." That's all he can manage to say. But the words don't do justice to what he truly feels for Tim. He loves him like the moon loves the sun, like a bird loves the sky, like a sailor loves the sea. Maybe... maybe even loves Tim like Lucifer loved God — with his whole being, greedily and blasphemously.

Tim stiffens for a moment in shock, and Jason tightens his grasp on him instinctively. He's not sure if he'd survive if the Light leaves him now.

But instead of rejecting him, instead of pushing him away like he *should*, Tim gently pries Jason's arms off himself. Just enough to sink to his knees next to him. The halo of light stays behind, above them, and so does the aura of unattainable grace. Here, on the floor, they're both mortal.

"I love you too," Tim whispers back. Despite the lack of divinity, his smile still feels like a blessing.

If five years ago someone had told Jason Todd that he would be dating Tim Drake, he would've called them insane. If someone had told him that a year ago, he would've laughed in their face. If someone had told him that a month ago, he would've said something snarky and hastily changed the topic.

And yet, here he is. Holding hands, getting coffee together, going for walks and exchanging late night texts with Tim Drake. Buying him flowers and reading him cheesy poetry out loud. Having his hands held, grabbing lunch together, going to the movies and exchanging "good morning :)" messages with Tim Drake. Receiving funky-looking pebbles and having video games excitedly explained to him.

It's a new, exciting feeling, to adore and be adored. It's a kind of devotion he hadn't known before. And though he still sometimes thinks of Tim as immaculate and holy, his affection for him... does not remain chaste. There's something in Jason yearning for more, longing for Tim's touch, aching to hold him close. He dreams of Tim like a man in the desert dreams of water; fantasises about feeling the gentle softness of Tim's body around his fingers, about knowing Tim's smooth, silky taste with his tongue, about feeling Tim's bright, refreshing smell deep in his throat.

Lust proves to be a confusing feeling to have. Despite all that desire coiling in his belly, Jason doesn't try to do anything about it. They both aren't exactly comfortable in their bodies, after all. Tim flinches away from hugs, and every spark of carnal interest in Tim's eyes makes Jason's skin crawl. Somewhere deep inside him is a scared animal convinced that pleasure is only ever taken from him, with violence if need be, not given or even shared. That intimacy always comes with pain. That affection is never his to experience. He bets there's a similar nightmare haunting Tim's thoughts.

Once again, Tim proves to be made of sterner stuff than Jason thought him to be.

He takes initiative and proves Jason's demons wrong. They start small, shy smiles and hands brushed together awkwardly. Part of the reason must be Tim's own terrors holding him back. But there's tenderness in his approach that cannot be explained away by self-preservation. He's careful and delicate in his advances, just like he's always been when Jason's mind got lost among his fears. He asks for permission to touch Jason and gives him time to refuse. Never holds it against him when he does. In turn, Jason does the same — only ever touches Tim where and when he's allowed to, even if he longs to caress every inch of Tim's skin with reckless abandon until Tim forgets how to think.

Bit by bit, they build trust in one another. Slowly and cautiously, coy smiles exchanged bashfully become timid pecks on the lips. Skittish hands wander and explore. Silence fills with quiet sighs. Time they spend together, though still prudent and shy, gradually starts feeling more and more... ardent. Passionate. Salacious, sinful even, if only because of what Jason imagines lies beyond the fleeting touches.

Like that, days turn into weeks turn into months. Time filled with many *first times*, though of other kinds than the one Jason imagines at night. None any less beautiful. First official date; first piece of cake eaten with a shared spoon. First proper, shameless kiss; sharing their relationship with the first family member. First movie night out; first time exchanging a sip of their milkshakes to share the flavours. And, inevitably, first shared moment of... vulnerability.

Five months into their relationship, instead of rushing to the door to greet him with a smile like he always had so far, Tim welcomes Jason into the Nest with suffocating silence. He leads Jason to the living room, slowly and cautiously, looking like a man marching to his death.

Jason sits down on the sofa, but Tim stays where he is — right next to the door as if he's securing his escape route. He keeps his eyes fixed on the floor, biting his lip and fidgeting with his fingers nervously.

"Timmy?" Jason asks softly, not to spook him. Tim doesn't respond, so Jason gives him space and time. His inner demons rear their ugly heads, smelling something to prey on. He does his damndest to ignore them, makes a conscious effort to smile. Tries to, at least, hoping his soaring anxiety doesn't show.

Eventually, Tim speaks up. "I have something to tell you."

Jason freezes for a split second. That doesn't sound good. "I'm listening." If nothing else, he is glad Tim decided to break up with him — he should've done it long ago, really — in a

gentle way.

"I haven't been honest with you," Tim begins, and Jason's heart sinks. He always expected this tryst to be short-lived, prepared himself for Tim leaving for someone that's not as *broken* as Jason is. But... if instead Tim... if Tim says he never really loved Jason— "I'm not... I'm not a real man."

Jason frowns, completely thrown off. Tim stares at him with wide eyes, waiting for a response, worrying the bottom hem of his shirt. His fingers are trembling and he looks terrified, vulnerable in a way Jason has never seen him before. Wanting to calm his nerves, Jason reaches out... but Tim moves away at the gesture like he's about to bolt, so Jason sits back down and waits. It seems that's the only thing he can do.

Tim's hands jerk a couple times; tiny, aborted movements that look like simply bigger surges of Tim's anxiety... until finally Jason understands what they truly are: Tim's failed attempts to battle himself and his fears. Eventually, one side prevails; Tim bites his lip so hard it goes white, shuts his eyes and slowly starts to lift the shirt he's holding. With each inch of his torso revealed, he's shaking even harder. When the shirt reaches his ribs, he pauses for a second, clawing at the sides of his ribcage like he's trying to prevent himself from going further.

Finally, Tim takes a deeper breath and lifts the shirt just above his collarbones.

As he exposes his bare chest in front of Jason for the first time, everything falls into place. How Tim always had a harder time putting on muscle mass, how he always reacted with unusual temper to Damian's insults about his height, how he never appeared in the changing rooms... and now the two thin, unassuming surgical scars, one under each of his pecs.

"I'm trans," Tim mumbles, as if he's still not sure Jason understands, hiding his face in the bunched-up fabric of his shirt. Jason never thought anything in this world could make Tim this scared and he finds himself at a loss of words. Him, who always has a snarky comment at the tip of his tongue, doesn't know what to say, what to do. At all.

When Jason stays weirdly silent, Tim lets go of his shirt, letting it fall back down. He wraps his arms around himself in an approximation of a hug, or maybe to hide the way his breath stutters and hitches at the brink of a sob. "I should've told you sooner, I know. I didn't mean to lie to you. I just... if— if you want to break up, I—"

At that, Jason finally reacts — he can't help but *burst into laughter*, overcome by the sheer *absurdity* of that *ridiculous* assumption. Him! Break up with Tim! As if this relationship wasn't a boon, a Grace he could never repay for, as if he would *ever* dare to push away someone as amazing as—

He shuts up fast when Tim pales and tenses his jaw to keep the tears welling in his eyes at bay. It's possibly only his vigilante training that prevents him from breaking down into a sobbing mess.

"I'm sorry!" Jason blurts out immediately, guilt surging in his chest and choking his words. "It's not— I didn't mean to laugh," he explains, struggling to find the right way to apologise. "I just— It changes nothing, *nothing at all*, between us. I promise," he assures him.

Tim stares at Jason, hesitant, like he's trying *so hard* to make himself believe those words.

"Aren't you angry?" he asks with suspicion. "Don't you think I'm... disgusting? Broken? Wrong?"

Jason's heart sinks, as he finally understands just how much it took for Tim to approach him about this. Is that what life taught Tim to think of himself? Is that what he assumed Jason would think too?

He jumps to his feet and is next to Tim in the blink of an eye. He still catches Tim's hands halfway through him taking a startled, scared step back.

"You are *the light of my life*," Jason says, slowly kneeling in front of Tim. "My *salvation*. How could I think of you as *anything else* than a *divine gift*?"

He places a soft, chaste kiss on the hands he holds. Tim gives him the kind of half-hearted smirk he always does when Jason says something cheesy, and there's a bit of genuine warmth in it. He relaxes, even if just a little.

"You really don't mind?"

"Would you like me to prove it?"

Redness immediately blooms on the tips of Tim's ears. Jason takes it as his cue to pull himself up, run a hand through Tim's hair and kiss his lips. His lover is slow to reciprocate, still a bit uneasy, but gives in. They stumble back, peppering each other's faces with fluttering kisses, until Tim's back hits the wall. There, their kisses gradually become faster, deeper, more passionate.

Jason's lips venture downwards, toward Tim's neck, earning him a heaved moan. He lingers there for a while, working on spreading the blush further across Tim's skin. His hands stay where they have had agreed they will — on Tim's head and arms, above his shoulders, nowhere else.

"What if—" Tim manages quietly, struggling to breathe and calm his excited heart. "What if you don't— what if you're not attracted to me?"

Jason quirks an eyebrow. "I thought we *just* established that I very much am." He gently nibs Tim's earlobe to drive his point home.

"You haven't seen..." Tim gestures vaguely to his lower body. "...the rest of me."

"I was attracted to you without seeing *any* of you. My devotion is not dependent on what you have in your pants."

It forces a startled, amused chuckle out of Tim, but the mirth in his voice is short-lived. He's silent for a moment, then sighs. "What about your faith?"

"What about it?"

“Doesn’t it say that being trans is defying G-d?”

He shakes his head and places a quick, reassuring peck on Tim’s cheek. “You are made in His image more than anyone else.”

Tim blinks, stunned. "What?"

"The Lord has made you as you are for the same reason He made grapes, but not wine, and wheat, but not bread. So that you too might partake in the act of creation."²

A good minute of hushed stillness follows that statement, only broken by laboured breaths and murmurs of Tim’s bewilderment. As the meaning and implications of those words gradually register in Tim’s mind, his expression changes several times; from confusion at first, through disbelief, finally into genuine, gawking wonder. When the tension in his shoulders melts away, anxieties finally soothed, he leans in to kiss Jason again.

It’s then Jason’s turn to flush bright red as Tim grabs him by the wrist and slowly places his hand on the small of Tim’s back.

That night Jason doesn't quite get to *unravel* Tim like he always desired to, but a precedent is set. The dam is broken. All the lust they've been holding back uncoils like a spring.

Within days Tim lets Jason touch his skin under the shirt, and within a few weeks he loses the shirt altogether as things get steamy. When an eventful patrol leaves them restless, they seek each other out on instinct and Jason gets a handful of Tim's ass while kissing the life out of him on a random rooftop. An intense sparring match makes their muscles thrum with excitement — so they end up grinding against each other right there on the mats, like the hormonal teens they never got to be. It almost gets out of hand.

It *does* get out of hand the next time Jason's worshipping Tim again, pressing prayers into his skin directly with his lips, leaving a trail of kisses along each and every scar and blemish. Preoccupied like that, he absentmindedly places his hand on Tim's abdomen, further down than he ever dared before. He doesn't get to correct himself, though. Between one moan and another, Tim guides the wandering hand down to his groin, causing Jason’s heart to skip a beat.

Jason doesn’t exactly have prior experience to rely on, so he goes in blind. He’d be a fool not to take the chance he’s been given. And it’s not like Tim needs much at that point, anyway. A few shaky strokes over Tim’s clothes and he arches his back, breathless, legs shivering. His expression in that moment is the most beautiful thing Jason has ever seen.

That hungry rush towards sensual experiences — experiences they’ve been denying themselves for so long — soon makes them stumble, crash and fall right into domesticity. The nightly rendezvous start interweaving with midnight snacks and having each other’s back in a fight without a second thought. Movie hangouts are just as likely to end with Jason dozing off peacefully on Tim's shoulder as they are with them kissing each other senseless while Tim’s straddling Jason’s lap. Their shared cases are dotted with brunches and makeout

sessions alike. It's not unusual for casework to carry them through the entire day and deep into the evening before they notice. Jason might as well list the Nest as his permanent residence with how much of his time he spends there.

"Let's wrap it up here," he comments on one of those long days. "We both need to grab something to eat and catch a couple hours of sleep." He stretches and puts down the folder he was going through.

It takes Tim a moment to hear him properly and look up from the document he's studying. He stares at Jason for a couple seconds, like he's trying to make him reconsider, then sighs and throws his arms into the air. "I guess! Yeah, fine."

Jason chuckles. The way Tim tries, uselessly, to resist and rebel against Jason's very sensible suggestions to rest is... endearing. At the beginning, it was a frequent point of conflict. Tim never thought about prosaic things like sleep or hunger, and would try to push himself past his limits. Jason always tried to talk some sense into him. In time, they've found a compromise. While Tim still forgets that he's a living being and has the needs of one, he at the very least agrees with Jason more readily. Sometimes, he even remembers about eating vegetables all on his own.

Jason would like to think that it's not just a simple force of habit. Instead, he likes to imagine that it's a genuine change of heart on Tim's part, and that he is at least partially responsible for it; that Tim saw how Jason treats him, how he cares for him and cherishes both his body and soul, and realised that that's how he *deserves* to be treated.

Even if it's not true, it's amusing for Jason to think of himself as a model of good behaviour and a positive influence, at the very least.

Whatever the reason, Tim agrees that they're due for a break, and that's what matters. Jason's shoulders and back feel stiff from being hunched over the past few hours, so he stands up to get the blood moving again. He walks over to the window and looks out. The sky is dark, clouds churning across it like in a cauldron, and the streets are freshly wet. It is still early October, but the ache in one of his old knee injuries says that the air outside is unpleasantly chilly. All things considered, he's not looking forward to the fifteen minutes drive he has ahead of him.

It's just more convenient to meet and work and hang out at the Nest, instead of figuring out which of his safehouses is actually *safe* to use that week. But it means he always has to drag himself back to his dump afterwards if he wants to sleep. Despite how close the two of them already are, he still feels out of place in Tim's life. Out of place in his home, at least.

"I wish I could just crash here," he mumbles absent-mindedly before his self-control catches up to his mouth.

"You can," Tim responds, trying to sound casual. He's not doing a good job of it. His tone is artificially level and his eyes are fixed on the text he read enough times to memorise it by now.

Jason stares at him in silence for a heartbeat, considering his options. It already felt kind of unfair to be fully covered in a damn turtleneck while Tim sits in his lap half-naked.

But he's... not sure he's ready just yet.

(Not sure if he ever will be.)

If he was to stay the night, hiding his skin would be a logistical nightmare. But he can't quite tell Tim that without it sounding... He doesn't know exactly *how* it would sound, but it would sound *bad*.

So he decides to turn it into a joke, like he always does with shit he doesn't want to engage with.

"No can do, birdie," he says, then sighs dramatically, curling his white streak of hair around a finger. "I don't have my bonnet with me. The curls would be a bitch to detangle in the morning."

Tim looks up at him with the *slightest* hint of a frown on his face. Jason crosses his arms on his chest, defiantly. It wasn't *him* who started this ridiculousness.

"I think you'll manage."

"But what about my fifteen-step Korean skincare routine? It's absolutely necessary for helmet-users like me."

"You can borrow my moisturiser."

"And my Wonder Woman stuffie? She can't sleep without me."

Tim sighs, finally *visibly* annoyed by Jason's antics. "Jason."

But Jason keeps going. "Not to mention my bed. I left my bed at home."

"*Jason.*"

"What? You started it."

"I wasn't joking."

"Neither was I. I don't even have a toothbrush!"

Tim stands up abruptly, keeping eye-contact with Jason, then marches off, leaving Jason stunned. He returns a moment later, only to slam a brand-new toothbrush, still in packaging, on the table. "I keep extras."

They stare each other down for a good minute. Finally, Tim sighs and breaks the silence.

"I can wear a blindfold," he offers. At first it sounds like an off the cuff comment, but Jason sees it for what it is. Much like he read through Tim's bluff when he got stabbed with rebar

back in the day, Tim now read through him and decided to cut to the chase.

It doesn't make his solution any less absurd.

"What."

"A blindfold."

"I heard you the first time around," Jason hisses, frowning. "In your own house?"

"I wouldn't mind."

"You're insane."

"I just want to make you feel comfortable."

Jason's expression sours. "Then how about you stop pressuring me to do something I very clearly don't want to?"

Tim gasps. "I'm sorry, I—"

"You what? Thought you knew better?" Jason offers with a scoff.

"No!" Tim stands up, walking over to where Jason's standing. He tries to take Jason's hands in his, but Jason pointedly takes a step away. Tim sighs, but doesn't follow him. "I just wanted you to know that you're welcome here, no matter what."

"*No matter what*," Jason repeats mockingly. "I doubt it."

"Someone wise once told me that devotion isn't dependent on what's under the clothes." Tim makes another slow attempt to touch Jason, and this time Jay lets him. He's still stiff and defensive, but Tim's gentle yet unyielding dedication chips away at his shell. "I didn't mean to pressure you into anything. I just tried to get you to stop deflecting. I know how unhelpful our brains can be sometimes. I want your decision to be based on what *you* want and if *you* feel ready. Not on how you imagine **I** would think or what I'd do."

That finally cracks Jason's stubborn resolve. He bites his lip, then hides his face in his hands. "It's not—" he starts, but words fail him. Feelings had always been hard for him, but this particular topic is especially difficult. Even more so because it's *Tim* who he's talking to. "I'm just—"

"Scared," Tim offers. Jason doesn't confirm, but he doesn't deny either. "I know that feeling very well." He gently takes Jason's hands off his face and leans in to look him in the eyes. "And I can sadly tell you it never... it never truly goes away. I wish it would. I wish I could kiss the fear out of you but... no amount of love will make that nasty voice in your head shut up."

Jason matches his gaze with hope in his eyes. "Then how did you—?" Because Tim did it, didn't he? He overcame his fears. He won against his demons. If it's not love — if Jason

can't just bask in Tim's Grace for long enough to be healed and mended and *whole* again... Then at least Tim can guide him, tell him what to do. Right?

Tim smiles sadly. "That's something you have to do on your own."

"I'm not like you. I'm... not strong enough."

"Neither was I." Jason frowns in confusion, so Tim elaborates. "I'm... not sure if I loved you more than I hated myself or... or I loved myself more than I loved you. But I knew that what we had couldn't be genuine without honesty. That I would always be wondering whenever your feelings would be the same if you knew, if I came out. I decided I'd rather tell you and get rejected than live a lie."

"I can't... I can't lose you."

Tim sighs. "And I don't want to lose *you*. But I do, bit by bit, every day that you kill a piece of yourself thinking I won't like it."

"You don't know what you're asking of me."

"You're right," Tim agrees plainly, causing Jason to blink in shock. "I don't. I don't know what you're feeling, what you're going through, what's going on in your head. I just believe that whatever it is, it won't change anything between us. But I don't *know*, I can't be *sure*. The same way I couldn't be sure that you'd still love me when I decided to come out to you. As it always is with these kinds of things... It's a leap of faith."

There's a beat of silence as Tim pulls himself up and kisses Jason's cheek, then hugs him. Jason melts into the embrace. "And I think we can both agree that your faith is by far stronger than mine."

Jason thinks about that exchange multiple times during the next few weeks, because hate it as he may... Tim's words were not without merit. What they have will never be genuine if Jason keeps deceiving Tim. If he keeps making him think he's better than he really is, that he's not a broken shell of his former self.

Jason knows that it's wrong, but he can't really say he cares what people label as "morally correct" these days. Now he also realises it's insidious. Selfish, at the very least. And Tim deserves better than a selfish partner. If nothing else, Jason thinks he should do it out of respect. If he really loves Tim, he should reveal what he really is. Let Tim decide for himself instead of doing whatever he can to keep him around.

But it's not what *really* makes him think of actually divulging his secret. The more Jason mulls over it, the more it becomes clear to him that he was *so* wrong in his predictions about the situation. A toddler could probably do a better job. Before, the idea to confess his sins to Tim would sound ludicrous, and the possibility that Tim would find out on his own used to send Jason into a blind panic. Now... it's a risk, and an unbelievably big one, but...

Tim has been nothing but loving and earnest towards Jason, repeatedly acting with tactful carefulness, even in times of strife and confusion. Nothing between them ever suggested Tim would react badly if Jason revealed his condition. The image Jason had in his mind — the vision of Tim frowning in disgust when he sees Jason's patchy skin, the cold aloofness setting in his eyes and posture, the way he hastily walks out without a word — would be such an uncharacteristic reaction that anyone who knows Tim would suspect he was a victim of mind-control or body-swapping of some kind.

Because unlike the Outlaws or the Bats or any other vigilante Jason has ever met, Tim has always treated him the same way each time. It used to be more hostile, back when they were more antagonistic towards each other, but at the core it's always been... respectful. Tim doesn't dish out fake concern like Dick does, nor treats Jason like a child as Bruce tends to. He shows no misplaced pity when Jason has a panic attack in his presence. Displays no charitable wariness when Jason's body or mind fail him. Gives him no sudden special treatment when Jason finds himself stuck in his past. Instead, he approaches Jason's fits of temporary hysteria the same way he does anything else he hadn't planned for — with calculated, cautious thoughtfulness.

That is to say, Tim's a good person. Better than all of them. It's partially why Jason fell so madly in love with him. And yet, Jason's subconscious insists that if Tim ever catches a *glimpse* of his skin, the world will end. If nothing else, even if Jason's issues are a deal-breaker... Tim would reject him gently. With a sad smile and a soft voice, like always when he says something that might distress Jason. To have had assumed Tim would be cruel instead feels... absurd. How could he, with his nigh-divine grace, be anything but merciful?

He becomes less scared of the prospect of revealing his secret and more... annoyed. At himself, mostly. For being dumb. And a coward. And, most importantly, a man of little faith.

Jason's sure it never was Tim's intention to insult him with that comment about faith, of course. That he never wanted to put Jason's devotion into question or attempted to imply that Jason doesn't trust him. That he never tried to insinuate that Jason's not a pious man. He's pretty certain Tim actually meant the opposite.

It still registered like a challenge. And Jason is, against his better judgement, a very competitive person. Even if the opponent is himself.

Not that it's enough to make him march into the Nest and take off his trusty three layers of turtlenecks in front of Tim, no. But when they stay up working late the next time, he announces the need to wrap it up for the night by pulling a toothbrush out of his bag (he's just as dramatic as he is competitive, after all).

Jason sees the flash of understanding in Tim's eyes, but doesn't comment. It's RR's signature approach, to keep quiet and analyse, though Jason suspects it's also Tim just being tactful.

Jason decides to see just how much Tim can take before snapping.

Tactful silence is Tim's approach as well when Jason — against all his instincts screaming for him not to — shows up to their date in a shirt without a high collar, his neck salaciously on display. (He doesn't have vitiligo patches there, but still feels vulnerable showing more skin

than usual. His anxiety managed to convince him to cover up as much as he can, *just in case*.) He is not moved by Jason asking for advice as if he's a dependent little kid. Finding Jason ugly-crying while chopping onions one night, face covered in snot and full-on sobbing like a wimp, gets no reaction either. He doesn't flinch with surprise when Jason casually drops that the big bad Red Hood is afraid of thunderstorms, doesn't even seem to care when Jay admits he's partially deaf in one ear from the many explosions in his life. Time and time again, he treats him the same, lovingly and without trepidation, even when Jason lets him see glimpses of how deficient he is. Tim acts as if he doesn't even notice it, though Jason's pretty sure that he recognises the gestures for what they are — tests.

So far, he's passing. Weirdly enough, Jason's not happy about it. He can't tell if Tim truly doesn't mind, or if Jason simply hasn't reached his snapping point yet. And it annoys him. He desperately *wants* to think that it's the former, that Tim loves him despite how defective he is... but he can't know for sure.

Once again in his life he finds himself frustrated about not being able to understand Tim and his motives. That annoyance builds up over a few months, simmering under his skin until it starts to boil over and seep out. It bleeds into his demeanour and interactions with others, making him even *more* of a callous asshole, full of snide quips and cutting comments. And while he doesn't really mind being more abrasive to Dick or Damian, his tantrums don't discriminate. Since Tim's the one that's around him the most, he ends up bearing the brunt of Jason's temper.

It puts a dent in Tim's patience. Every mean word and bratty exploit chips away at his composure. Sure, he usually just frowns or sighs, and calls Jason to order if he really acts out of line; sternly reminds him, "Jay, I'm not your enemy," or gently asks, "Do you need a moment, babe?" But Jason can tell that each time, Tim's patience is running thinner and thinner.

On one hand, Jason deeply regrets exposing Tim to his outbursts; feels guilty for not being *better*, not *pretending* to at least — for being unable to hide his anger or control it. Especially when it's obvious they affect him so much. On the other... the vicious, cruel little demon in the back of his mind is *delighted*.

It's a duality he hasn't been able to rid himself of. He hopes beyond hope that Tim really can love a sinner and a freak like Jason, because he desperately *wants* to be loved. And he also hopes that Tim *doesn't* love him enough to overlook how ugly and monstrous he is, because Tim can do *so much better* than Jason.

That conflicting feeling smashes into him like a truck a few weeks later, on a freezing-cold January morning. They're sleepy, hungry and crabby, both of them battered after a mission gone sideways and exhausted after a really long trip home. It's very obvious that even Tim's fuse is particularly short that day.

It's the perfect day to finally break Tim and have the relationship go out with a bang, like everything good in Jason's life.

It's not even intentional. He's simply not built to be gentle and considerate like Tim is. And so, despite Tim having a raging headache, Jason's movements are extra clumsy and loud due to fatigue while he pulls out the plates and cutlery for breakfast. When Tim off-handedly asks him to turn on the coffee machine while he sets the table, Jason conveniently doesn't hear him. And as Jason serves the food, he manages to spill half of the instant oatmeal straight into Tim's lap.

Tim curses under his breath. Jason tries to save the situation and help him clean up, but instead he accidentally knocks over Tim's favourite mug, full of three shots of espresso, sending it crashing to the floor. The hot liquid splashes over Tim's slippers and burns his feet and ankles.

The room falls silent. They both stay frozen for a heartbeat, then Tim hides his face in his hands.

Jason takes a shaky, quiet breath in, afraid that every noise will set Tim off. He's sure that he's done for. He finally overstayed his welcome. The dam holding back the consequences of his wrongdoings is broken. Tim's going to explode, his patience for Jason's inadequacy finally running dry.

He takes a slow step back, putting distance between them, as if he's afraid Tim's going to get violent. The thought that he's also a vigilante himself, and has almost 60 pounds of muscle on Tim, doesn't stop him from being scared. In his mind, he can already hear the way Tim's going to yell at him any moment now. Yell, until he's out of breath, that Jason is inept and useless and a waste of space, then throw him out like the trash he is.

(Imaginary Tim's voice is weirdly similar to the way Jason's father sounded when he screamed in rage, back in the day, but Jay — curled up in the back of his mind like a cornered animal — doesn't notice that kind of nuance anymore.)

Then Tim exhales and groans, lowering his hands. Instead of being red with anger and hatred, his face is simply... more tired.

"Can you get the mop?" he just requests, smiling weakly. Jason's too shocked to even blink. "Jay?" Tim asks when there's no response. "Are you okay?"

Jason manages to get his voice to work again with some effort. "You're not... angry?" he stutters out hesitantly.

Tim tilts his head in confusion.

"I very much am," he admits and shrugs. "But getting angry at oatmeal seems rather pointless."

"But— *I* fucked up. I thought that you'd—"

"... that I'd be angry at *you*?"

Jason gives him a stilted nod in response.

“You’ve just been a bit distracted. We’re both barely standing, I can’t say I’d do any better than you at this point.”

“You... you still have patience for me? Even after I’ve been *so* nasty over the past few weeks?”

Tim stares at him for a moment, then sighs. “You... yeah, you’ve been a pain in the ass lately, and I can’t say it hasn’t been getting on my nerves. But I also know you’re not doing it on purpose. I’ve been stressed before, you know, it’s not like I don’t understand that it can cause someone to be a bit more of a prick than usual.” Tim gives him a friendly jab in the ribs, signalling it was a joke, but Jason can’t find it in himself to laugh. Seeing that, Tim takes on a more serious tone. “You’re dealing with something. Something that’s difficult and personal, something that I can’t support you through. The least I can do is brush off when you’re being a little bratty.”

They stay silent for a moment. Then Jason sits down on the next chair over, suddenly feeling dizzy and overwhelmed.

“Fuck,” he mumbles, putting his elbows on the table and resting his forehead against his hands. “I really don’t deserve you. I don’t fucking deserve you, like, at all.”

“You don’t,” Tim agrees with a smirk.

It’s not like Jason thinks Tim’s wrong or shouldn’t say it, but still — he supposes it would’ve probably hurt less if Tim stabbed his heart and twisted the knife a few times.

To his surprise, Tim continues, and in a direction Jason hadn’t expected.

“But isn’t that kind of the point of love? Like what one of your Saints said, I think it was Augustine of Hippo? How did he phrase it... ‘God has given you Grace not *because* you have been faithful, but *so that* you can be faithful’? Something like that. And I’m not G-d, obviously, but I think that’s true about *all* love. You can’t *deserve* love. Love is given freely, dependent only on the one giving it. You can’t *make me* love you just as much as you can’t *stop me* from loving you.”

Jason stares at him stunned, mouth agape.

“You’ve read Catholic theology?” is what his mind latches on instead of processing his befuddled feelings.

“Some of it. Can’t say it’s a very captivating read for the most part, but there are some interesting takes in there.”

“But— but you’re not even Christian?”

“So?” Tim shrugs. “You are. I wanted to take a peek into your mind. Thought if I knew what’s making up your worldview, I might understand you a bit better.”

Jason blinks in confusion. “Why? What for?”

Tim shrugs again.

“I’d like to say it’s simply because I love you and *want* to know you. It’s not a lie, but in the end it’s just a smooth, easy half-truth to tell you. The honest answer is... because I’m an over-competent little shit that rationalises everything, that’s why.” He looks up at Jason expectantly, then sighs and smiles sourly when it’s obvious that his joke failed to brighten the mood. “I thought that if I can understand your feelings, maybe I can help you look at yourself in a better light.”

And at that moment, Jason finally understands what Tim meant when he said “*I loved you more than I hated myself*”. How can Jason continue to hurt him, how can he keep misleading and using someone as unbelievably *good*, as genuinely *compassionate* as Tim?

He can’t.

“However many flaws and faults you thought I had,” he starts, voice shaking only *a little*, “however many failings you thought you could look past... it’s so much worse. And there’s not much in me that could make up for it. Whoever you thought you love... it’s not me. And I’m so, *so sorry* that I led you on for this long.”

He can barely see with how full of tears his eyes become in nearly an instant. Before the scared animal in the back of his mind can catch up, he takes his shirt off in one quick, decisive movement.

Tim blinks, staring at Jason’s exposed skin in shock. “Oh. Um.”

“Do you understand me better now?” Jason asks, his voice finally giving out and cracking, making him sound even more *broken*. “Do you finally get why I have to keep myself a secret?”

Tim blinks again, then looks up at Jason. “Honestly, not really,” he says, sounding half-confused and half-apologetic.

Jason frowns. Does Tim not grasp the weight of what he sees? Does he not understand the symbolism, the meaning?

“I’m an accursed thing,” he begins explaining. It’s easier to say it out loud than he thought it would be, to point out just how wretched he is. Maybe he repeated it in his mind enough times for the words to become thoughtless, like a prayer. “It’s not that— it’s not *just* that I *look* hideous. I *am* hideous, down to the core. I’m just as *vile* as everyone always said I am. I tried to masquerade as *good*, but God wrote all my sins on my skin so I can’t hide who I am anymore. Covered me in blemishes and scars to match my *monstrous* soul.”

Jason lowers his gaze down at the floor, unable to look Tim in the eyes in fear that he might, after all, see the *disgust* and *anger* he had expected. Because of that, he misses the tears that start running down Tim’s cheeks until Tim grabs him by the wrist and drags him into a hug. He only manages to make a surprised little squeak before he’s tightly embraced by Tim’s arms.

“Oh Jason,” Tim whispers into his ear, swallowing back a sob. “You’re no more monstrous than I am.”

Jason can’t help but hiccup with a misshapen, barking laugh. “I really am. You’re *perfect* compared to me. Ask literally *anyone*.”

“I don’t care what anyone else says!” Tim cries out, then falls silent when Jason tenses up in his arms. He remains silent for a good while, but his hold on Jason doesn’t ease even the slightest. He must be formulating the perfect sentence to express what he thinks. He probably wants to continue trying to change Jason’s mind, convince him of his goodness. It’s a futile endeavour, but Jason lets him come to that conclusion on his own.

When Tim finally speaks up again, what comes out of his mouth shocks Jason nearly into a stupor.

“Can I love you regardless?”

“Huh?” is all Jason manages to stutter out in response.

“I’d like to stay at your side, even if you feel that what you’ve shown me means you’re... hideous.”

Jason frowns. “...why?”

Tim smiles sadly. “Have you considered that if devotion is not dependent on what’s under the clothes, then it perhaps also doesn’t care what the skin might mean?”

And Jason doesn’t fully understand why, but his heart feels like it freezes, then cracks and falls apart. He hugs Tim back, crying, and doesn’t let go until his limbs go numb.

It takes Jason a few months to wrestle with what Tim said. The rest of winter is uneventful and unremarkable in comparison, and before long their second spring together rolls in. The inescapable turning of seasons makes Jason finally settle on resigned acceptance. He’s shown Tim what he is. Tried his best to convince him to leave, for his own good if nothing else. But Tim stayed. Against all Jason’s predictions and beliefs, against any reasoning Jay could understand, Tim stayed.

There’s only two explanations for that — either Tim is blinded by his emotions, made stupid by love, or he sees something *redeemable* in Jason. Given that there’s few people in the world smarter and more rational than Tim, only one of those is a viable option.

So Jason accepts his affection and gives up trying to push him away. Who is he to question someone clearly so much closer to divinity than he is? After all, Tim’s like Love itself, if one is to go by the definition in the Letter to Corinthians. He is patient and kind. He is not easily angered, and keeps no record of Jason’s many wrongs. Always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres.

Maybe Tim really *is* an Angel, Jason ponders, a Saint that God sent to save him. Maybe in loving him, Jason can reach salvation. And even if not, Jason being at his side seems to make Tim *happy*. That's as close to Heaven as Jason thinks he can get these days.

In time, Jason's acceptance of Tim's love and his determination to forever reciprocate it makes his inner demon... not silent, but a bit more *mellow*. The voice in his head doesn't go away, but the pain it inflicts has lost its edge with Tim's warmth dulling it into a faint ache instead.

Tim must see it, notice the way Jason smiles more often now. He extends an open and indefinite invitation for him to drop by the Nest, even gives Jason his own key. It becomes the place where Jason spends the most of his days, coming over every time he has a free moment. Not to help, not to be of use, not to do anything in particular — just to hang out, to exist next to Tim, because next to Tim he *can* simply *be*. It's a place where he is welcomed; a safe harbour where he not only *can* be himself, but is *encouraged* to do so. It's especially precious to him since he hasn't had much chance to experience it in his life before.

March goes by smoothly, and soon Easter looms on the horizon. Without his own permanent residence to spring clean in blind fervor, Jason passes the time watching Tim try to act like he cares about cleaning at all. This particular day Tim chose the kitchen as his battlefield, so Jason follows him as he puts his extensive mug collection away into the cupboards, pretends to have a discussion with the salt shaker, uses the pots as drums and does a little dance to the impromptu music. It's nothing special, nothing Jason hadn't seen before. And yet the sight fills him with joy because of how... domestic it is. Despite everything, against all odds... Tim's his, and he's Tim's. This handsome, amazing, brilliant man *chose him* to be a part of his life.

Tim catches his gaze and smiles at him, chuckling softly. It's the same kind of bright, pearly chuckle that made Jason face the music long ago and profess his love for him in the first place. It melts Jason's heart the same way it did back then.

He leans back to fully appreciate just how breathtakingly beautiful Tim is. His mind immediately reaches for the most striking comparisons, the loveliest descriptors, the finest poetry Jason knows — the Song of Songs. Tim's worthy of it, after all.

And so in Jason's mind Tim's eyes become like doves behind the luscious veil of lashes, his lips like a scarlet ribbon stretched out in a vibrant smile. His deft hands are like young fawns, twin gazelles; nimble and sleek. Despite his relatively petite posture, he doesn't look fragile — he seems magnificent like the grand walls of Jerusalem instead, as formidable and majestic as an army under banners.

Jason's heart tightens, heavy with emotion, when he verbalises his admiration like that. He wants to reach out to Tim, do something, *say* something at least, to express just how *wonderful* he thinks Tim is, how ardently Jason feels for him, just how hopelessly in love with him he is.

He finds only one way to do it in that moment, one thing he can do to declare his love beyond any doubt.

"I'm a virgin." It feels fitting to offer himself up once more in the morning sun like when he first confessed, in the middle of the very same kitchen. A bit like it's becoming a tradition.

Tim stops dead in his tracks, beautiful blush creeping across his face. He blinks, staring at Jason like a deer caught in the headlights. Long ago, it would make Jason unbelievably nervous and scared. Now, he just patiently waits for him to find his words.

"Oh. Well. I— Um. So am I?" Tim stammers out, unsure where the conversation is supposed to go.

"I think... I think I'd like my first time to be with you."

(He had asked his confessor — the poor man really doesn't have an easy life with him — what he can do about his more... *lascivious* bodily desires. Premarital sex is a sin, after all, and even though same-sex marriage isn't illegal anymore in many countries, it's still impossible for someone who's *legally dead*. The priest offered him a very elegant solution. "Do you think God needs government-regulated paperwork to recognise a marriage?" he asked Jason solemnly. "Or just the intent of lifelong faithfulness and love?" And, well. Jason *does* intend to stay with Tim *until death does them apart*. Given his track record with dying, possibly even past that, so long as Tim would have him.)

Tim smiles, but it's faint and weak. "I'm... honoured," he says, worrying the damp kitchen rag in his hands. "But I... I don't think I'm ready to..."

"You don't have to!" Jason assures him. "I'm not saying you have to. Now, or ever. I just... I'm just offering."

Tim exhales loudly, relaxing his shoulders. They trust each other deeply, yes, but that doesn't mean these kinds of exchanges aren't still nerve-wracking.

"It's not that," Tim says, putting down the rag and walking over to Jason. He gently cups Jason's face with his hands and looks him in the eyes. "I'd love to, with you. But I... I think I'd feel too much like *a woman* if you..." He nods downwards awkwardly, hoping to convey with it the thing he can't make himself say.

"Oh," is all Jason manages, stunned slightly. It completely slipped his mind that the *how* might be an issue.

Tim offers him a shrug. "Yeah."

Jason stays silent for a moment, thinking. "Well. I didn't have any specific configuration in mind, if that changes anything?"

"W-what?"

"I'm volunteering to catch."

Tim loses a beat in confusion, but when the meaning registers, he turns an even darker shade of red. "Oh. I..." He blinks, caught off-guard once again. "I thought..."

Jason smirks playfully. “Just because I’m taller doesn’t mean I have to do all the work in bed, Timmy,” he teases, hoping to make the conversation a bit less awkward. It works, because Tim puffs his cheeks in feigned indignation. Jason leans in, so close their noses almost touch. “I’m not the only one with a penis here, now am I?”

“My packers— they aren’t— you can’t use them like *that*,” Tim manages to stammer out. The indignation might be fake, but the embarrassment isn’t. “And you know it.”

“We could get you a dick that’s not just for show, darling.”

That finally breaks through Tim’s shyness for good. He snorts and weakly shoves Jason away, laughing. “Don’t say it like that!”

“Only when it stops making you laugh, dear.” Jay grins, then kisses him on the nose. “Shops these days have all the shapes and colours you could imagine. I bet you’d look dashing with a bright red cock.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“You love me for that.”

“I do. Regrettably.” Tim sighs, then rests his head against Jason’s chest, intertwining their hands. “Do you mean it, though? *Really* mean it?”

“Absolutely. But don’t feel pressured, of course. Just know that it’s on the table.”

Tim remains silent for a second. “I’ll... give it thought.”

“That’s all I ask.”

Tim sends him a blurry photo of an *actual* bright red dildo a week later. Jason nearly walks into a streetlamp, staring at the screen of his phone. Especially since its closely followed by a text inviting him over during the weekend, ended with an eggplant emoji to that.

The two days between then and Saturday are one of the most difficult times in his life, honestly. Most nerve-wracking at the very least. His blood pressure is constantly high due to the mix of excitement and stress. Will it be as good as the world made it sound? What if Tim changes his mind? What if Jason does something wrong? What if he hurts him?

Jason enters the Nest with wobbly legs and a faint heart. He’s done everything he could to prepare, in terms of both reading up and washing up beforehand. Doesn’t make it any less weird to think about what’s going to happen later tonight.

It brings him some solace that Tim’s just as anxious. They stare at each other for a moment in the hallway, then Tim bursts into a nervous giggle.

“Looking at us, you’d think we’re about to go into an arena to fight to the death.”

“Yeah,” Jason mumbles, “I think I’d be more confident about a cage fight.”

Tim smiles. “We don’t have to, you know. We can watch that new Three Musketeers movie instead.”

“I’m not backing out.” Jason eyes him. “Are you?”

Tim crosses his arms on his chest defiantly. “What did I tell you about trying to use me as an excuse for your own insecurities?”

Jason frowns, but there’s no bite in his words. “Fuck you.”

“The plan was the opposite, wasn’t it?” Tim grins mischievously.

Jason grins back and takes his shoes off. When he straightens back up, Tim grabs him by the collar and pulls him closer. Their lips meet, the kisses slow and sensual at first. But every touch eases their anxiety a little, and soon enough they fall right back into their usual routine of barely controlled arousal. It doesn’t take long before they stumble towards the bedroom.

He has been to Tim’s bedroom before. Usually to grab a blanket for their movie hangouts, or a warm hoodie for when Tim underestimated the weather. One time he had to haul Tim to bed when he collapsed from exhaustion during a bout of stubbornness, and he even napped here once himself. This is not a room he’s never seen. There is no mystery or mystique to this place. And yet, with the lights dimmed and fresh sheets smelling vaguely of sea breeze, it feels different. It feels cosy and welcoming and... safe.

Tim pushes him against the bed and Jason has no issue free-falling onto it, his sheer mass causing the mattress to squeak in protest. He looks at Jason with half-lidded eyes, smiling warmly and blushing slightly, and any doubts Jason had about this whole thing fades away. This is what he wants. This is what they both want. Whatever happens, they’ll be in it together, and that’s everything Jason needs to face the world and come out victorious.

He reaches towards Tim and pulls him down. Pressed against each other, it’s natural to resume kissing, but it’s less... hurried and hungry. Somehow, hidden away from the world in the depths of the Nest, they stop feeling like their time together is short and limited. Here, they have forever to savour each other.

And they do. Finally... fully, now that each decided to trust the other with his whole body.

Jason spends a disproportionate amount of time kissing every inch of Tim’s face and neck, enjoying how each touch of his lips makes Tim squirm and blush. But Tim gives as good as he gets and before they know it, they’re both short of breath and the temperature between their bodies feels like it could rival the sun.

Somewhere in the meantime, as is usual, their shirts end up on the floor in a forgotten heap. Tim pauses briefly when his hands wander downwards and he tugs on Jason’s pants as if he wants to check in if everything is okay — but Jason just bites his lip with an inviting smirk and raises his hips to encourage Tim to pull the clothes off him. Tim laughs and obliges. Soon enough, they both lose everything but their underwear.

That is when Jason decides to be a little brave, a little *extra*. He pushes Tim away a bit to get some space, and scrambles to his knees with his chest puffed out. The pride in his posture is still a bit fake, but he undoubtedly came a long way.

He grins, hooking his thumb under the waistband of his briefs. “Would you like to see the goods?”

Tim snorts. “Yes, please,” he says earnestly, playing along.

“It’ll cost you one kiss.”

He quirks an eyebrow, smirks, then leans down and kisses the front of Jason’s underwear before Jason has the chance to react. “Is this enough?” he asks coyly, but the spark in his eyes is positively mischievous.

Jason tries to reply, but can’t get a coherent word out. Instead of saying anything, he puffs his blushing cheeks in feigned indignation, causing Tim to chuckle and place another peck on the fabric. “Can I help you with it?” Tim asks, batting his eyelashes. Looking down at Tim with his face right next to his dick, Jason only manages a strangled approving noise.

The kissing then resumes, along Jason’s thighs and around his pelvis, causing him to fall back onto the bed and melt into a flushed, quietly whining mess. He whimpers when Tim begins uncovering the last hidden parts of his skin, and fully starts to moan when the pecks morph into longer kisses and licks, leaving a wet trail of devotion to mark the progress.

Tim doesn’t pause when the briefs are fully off and gone, not giving either of them the time to doubt themselves. Instead, he licks Jason’s already half-hard shaft, sending a shiver through Jason’s spine and causing him to cry out loudly. He doesn’t get to be embarrassed about it, though, because Tim doesn’t stop. He runs his tongue up and down and around Jason’s dick until it hardens fully with arousal, his fingers fluttering across Jason’s thighs.

Jason tries to curse under his breath, mortified about how easily he’s coming apart under Tim’s machinations. He only manages a shuddering inhale as Tim takes the tip into his mouth and sucks gently. If this is how good it feels to be touched there by Tim without the clothes to muffle the sensations, he’s not sure he’s going to last till the actual *sex* starts. He has to do *something* about it.

“H-how are the—” he attempts, trying to regain at least *some* composure with a quip.

Tim’s lips pop off Jason’s dick with a wet sound. “Marvellous, but these are not the goods I’m after,” he replies, then raises Jason’s legs by the knees and dives further down.

All Jason can do when he feels Tim’s lips on his taint is to make a high-pitched, strangled noise. His hands grip the bedsheets at his side and his breath hitches. To his surprise, after the initial shock, his body relaxes without issue — quite to the contrary, even. Before he can realise what he’s doing, he shifts and presses his ass firmly against Tim’s face in an invitation.

He can't see it, but he fully knows in his heart that Tim grins in response to that, his ego stroked. He's a prideful gremlin like that, but so is Jason, so he can't really call him out on it. Then there's shuffling and Tim moves away for a brief moment, giving Jason a little respite. He peeks over to see Tim pull out a bottle of lube from under the bed. It's something Jason had thought about before, but unlike Tim, didn't have the presence of mind to remember about *now*.

"You ready?" Tim asks, attentive and caring as always. Jason smiles and nods.

"Don't keep me waiting, darling."

Tim squeezes some of the gel onto his palm and thoughtfully rubs it between his fingers to warm it up a bit. Jason lifts his hips again as if he's asking him to hurry, smirking, but the arrogance fades once he gets what he's asking for.

Tim's slender, calloused fingers, slick and silky with lubricant, flutter over his hole as if testing the waters. Jason whimpers. It's a weird feeling, completely foreign to him, but not at all unpleasant. Especially when he notices the way Tim stares at him with glossy, mesmerised eyes.

"You're beautiful," Tim whispers, suddenly overcome with emotions. He looks up and crawls over to kiss Jason, who flushes with a deep, crimson blush nearly all the way down to his belly button. It's one thing for Tim to occasionally call him pretty... and completely another to hear him say it while looking at Jason's naked body with the kind of awestruck wonder usually reserved for the frescoes of Sistine Chapel or the stained glass masterworks of the Sagrada Familia basilica.

But appreciation of beauty doesn't stop Tim from continuing to methodically unravel Jason nerve by nerve, muscle by muscle. He kisses him one more time, then goes back to massaging Jason's hole with a single finger, slowly and tenderly. The other hand lazily runs over Jason's legs and stomach, gently caressing the heated skin. Each touch relaxes Jason a little bit more, melting away anxieties he held deep in his bones.

Within minutes, he becomes limber and malleable for Tim — both literally and figuratively. When Tim's fingertip breaches him and slips inside, just barely, Jason doesn't gasp or tense up in shock. Instead, he moans quietly and shifts his legs farther open. Seeing that, Tim grins with the kind of self-satisfaction and delight on his face that a shepherd dog would have after skillfully corralling a challenging flock.

It takes only a bit more effort and time for Tim to be able push farther into Jason, and just a few minutes later he can ease another finger in. After that, he's knuckle-deep in Jason with three whole fingers in no time, though it still feels like ages for both of them.

Finally content with Jason's state, Tim blindly reaches under the bed again, seemingly unable to look away from Jason, and fishes out the strap-on. It's the same brilliantly red model that he'd sent Jason a photo of. When Tim slips into the harness, securing it on his hips, Jason can't help but notice that he does indeed look rather dapper.

Jason takes a few steadying, deep breaths, now that he can without Tim coaxing moans out of him all the time. Then he pulls his knees up, exposing himself further. He wants to say something clever and witty to distract himself from the sudden feeling of tightness in his chest. All he manages is a shy smile and an encouraging nod at Tim.

Tim doesn't need to be told twice.

He shuffles closer and carefully aligns himself with Jason's pelvis. Places his hands on his lover's hips, for stability as much as for comfort, resting the tip of the strap-on against Jason's hole. It's a little colder than Tim's skin, but Jason doesn't get to ponder it for long as Tim pushes forwards a little. There's only a moment of resistance before it breaches Jason, causing him to gasp softly, and then he's officially not a virgin anymore.

They both pause for a heartbeat, breathless with the realisation.

The feeling is... new. It stings a little at first, despite the generous amount of lube that Tim used. The toy is harder and girthier than Tim's fingers, after all, and doesn't yield at the mere hint of any discomfort like Tim did. But Jason is pliant for his lover. He makes an encouraging, rumbling noise, much akin to a purr, to show he's ready for more. Reassured, Tim presses on, gently and steadily, until their bodies are flush against each other. The dildo becomes a solid pressure, deep in Jason's gut, strange but pleasurable. It makes him feel full, heavy in a grounding way, and he finds himself unable to contain the satisfied moan that bubbles in his throat.

Tim stays still for a moment, amazed at Jason's open, deferential submission. Then he reaches out for Jason's hand, brings it to his face and kisses it. Jason smiles, petting Tim's cheek and rubbing his thumb over the lips caressing his hand.

They savour the moment of intimacy for a while, but eventually Tim grabs onto Jason's hips again.

"I'm going to make you feel *so good*," he whispers solemnly, then resumes moving.

It's slow and measured; Tim is as careful as always, even when brimming with desire. The toy grinds against Jason's insides and every thrust brings more of that weirdly pleasant burn deep in his belly. He punctuates Tim's movements with breathy moans, but the embers in his loins, though delicious, aren't the most gratifying thing about this endeavour.

It's Tim's expression. His half-lidded eyes fixated on Jason, full of warmth and adoration. His fingers gripping Jason tightly, as if he never ever wants to let go. His mouth, slightly ajar halfway through a gasp, making little grunts of effort and pleasure alike, in sync with Jason's own noises.

Jason whimpers, biting his lip. He doesn't know what it is, but he realises that something... *everything* about it is too much. In a *good* way, but just *too much*. Every thrust and every kiss Tim bestows on him is gentle and caring. Focused on him, *towards* him in a way he's never experienced before.

He raises his arms, trying to hide his face in his palms, trying to look like he's muffling a moan. He knows that if Tim sees his face now — sees the turmoil and doubt — he'll stop, and Jason doesn't want him to stop. He *can't* have him stop.

But Tim's too observant to fall for it and too caring let it slide. He slows down, reaches up and tenderly peels Jason's hands off his face.

"Hey?" he asks softly.

"I'm okay." Jason looks away. "Just... overwhelmed a bit."

Tim smiles, slowing the already gentle movements of his hips even more, and leans down to kiss Jason's soft belly. He doesn't ask, he doesn't judge, he doesn't pressure. He simply gives Jason time and space to figure it out instead. Once again, he preserves Jason's dignity as if it's nothing to him.

And once again it makes him seem *Holy*.

Tears immediately roll down Jason's cheeks, abundantly and uncontrollably. He can't quite understand why. After all, his entire body hums with pleasure, simmering just under his skin, and for the first time ever it doesn't feel... wrong. He feels *celebrated*. Everything is good and right.

And yet, it scares him.

Tim freezes, as Jason predicted. He wipes the wetness off Jason's face. "Are you sure everything's alright? We don't have to—"

Jason just smiles weakly in response, leaning into the touch and kissing the inside of Tim's palm. Tim responds with a warm smile, but the worry in his eyes doesn't go away. "Talk to me, Jay."

Jason doesn't know what to say, how to convey what he's feeling. How could words even *start* to convey his emotions? The way his heart feels light and free for the first time, and yet he is more grounded and present than he's even been before? And how all of that is thanks to Tim?

"I — Please —," he just mumbles, reaching up for Tim. "Please, I can't —"

Tim tenses and tries to pull away, probably thinking Jason's having a panic attack. Or doubts, at the very least. That *something* must be upsetting him if he's being this incoherent again, and the last thing Tim would do is try to push through Jason's discomfort.

But Jason doesn't let him go. Instead, he wraps his legs around Tim's hips, locking them together. "Don't— don't go," he manages to whisper, then tries to pull Tim closer to himself again. Tim lets him this time.

Jason touches their foreheads together for a moment. Partially to enjoy the closeness, partially to give himself time to think.

He has always struggled with how he perceives Tim. Rationally, he knows Tim's a human just like him. He's seen him curse and fight and roll in the mud, mortal to the core. Saw him bleed, with blood the same shade of red as his own. But Tim also always appeared to have an inexplicable light in him, something otherworldly that Jason couldn't quite put a name to. A strength, a gentleness that Jason would swear had to come from the Holy Spirit itself.

He never could quite reconcile the two images of Tim in his mind. Not for a lack of trying! But they were like a kaleidoscope, an ever-changing arrangement of colours; swirling together, yet never really combining. Tim would usually start human, struggling against the world like them all. Then he'd do something that Jason considered close to a miracle, effortlessly and with grace and beauty and all his flaws would pale into non-existence. That is, until the next time he stumbled, his failings cracking the façade of perfection, making him mortal again.

It felt bad to think of him like that. Not only was it definitely blasphemous — to compare Tim to divinity, to even sometimes think of Tim *as* the Divine, was verging on sacrilege. But it also felt very *unfair* towards Tim. It felt like... like Jason never was completely true in his love for him. You can never fully be *with* someone you see as *transcendent*, after all.

Somewhere deep inside him, Jason has always known that *he's* the problem that's causing this. That it's not about Tim or what he does at all. It's just that... A long time ago, the notion that Jason's intrinsically sinful and wretched dug its claws into his heart and grew to be the core pillar of his beliefs. Being afforded empathy and compassion became an alien concept. To the point that he believed it required godly perfection and divine grace to love a pathetic sinner like him.

So when Tim came around, it was... easier to see someone loving him as *divine* than it was to see himself as *lovable*. He considered loving him as something only a saint could do, and that inevitably raised Tim up to sainthood.

But as Saint Augustine said, "there is no saint without a past, no sinner without a future".

And now... The colours of the kaleidoscope start to mix. The reverence and the lust he feels towards Tim blend together, forming something different. Something grander than the sum of its parts. At last, Tim becomes a fully realised creation in Jason's eyes. He finally sees Tim as his true, multi-faceted self, and he's *beautiful*, so much more than he's *ever* been before. He's soft, and earnest, and attentive, and the divine spark shines in his eyes as bright as ever; yet he's also sweaty and dirty and so very, very grounded, with his undeniably mortal heartbeat thrumming against Jason's skin. And for the first time, the two don't stand in opposition.

Jason feels so cherished, so adored, so valued — not *despite*, but *because* of how awkward and clumsy, how *human* their intimacy is. He feels loved so *thoroughly* that he no longer can deny that it's *possible* to love him.

"Jason?" Tim chimes up again, trying to check in with him. Jason finally finds the only words that are fitting for the situation.

"I love you."

Tim blinks in surprise.

"I love you," Jason repeats, realising he's finally saying it with his whole heart, finally *genuinely*. For the first time without doubt, without feeling like there's something missing. *"I need you. Please don't stop. I can't— words, but... don't stop."*

He starts kissing him, hungrily and passionately. Tim grins against Jason's lips and resumes thrusting into him. It earns him a muffled moan.

Jason can't quite tell if it's because of the weight of his self-inflicted guilt now off his chest, or because of the changed position of his hips. Maybe Tim is more bold, too, going faster than before. Either way, it's different. *Better*.

He can feel Tim deeper, harder, longer. Instead of just being a new, vaguely pleasurable sensation, the dildo inside of him becomes... a blaze. Red, hot and exciting. Every time Tim moves, it ignites a spark deep in Jason's belly, a shiver that starts at his core and runs along his spine. And like bellows fanning a fire, Tim doesn't give the heat in Jason's veins even a single moment of peace — makes it grow stronger and stronger, without any time to calm down and subdue.

As the pressure in Jason's loins builds, his muscles start to tense without his conscious intent. He pulls Tim even closer with one arm, bringing them flush against each other with only enough room to let Tim keep moving his hips. The other hand falls onto the linens under them and grasps them, hard and relentless, as if that could help Jason handle everything he feels. His breaths become shaky, then morph into strained, breathless moans and whines punctuating Tim's thrusts.

Like this, it doesn't take him long. His core tightens, then he gasps and chokes on air, only to whimper quietly as the tension in him melts away nearly in an instant. In its wake, only warmth and comfort remains.

Jason takes a deep, slow breath in, trying to process what just happened. It's not like he has never climaxed before. He was a teenager once, after all. But this was different, and he's not entirely sure why or how.

Maybe it's because it happened entirely without touching his dick. Maybe it's because it was with someone else instead of on his own. Maybe it's because it was with *Tim*.

Maybe it was because he finally didn't feel guilty about it.

Jason doesn't really care much.

He blinks, trying not to become a useless, orgasm-drunk heap and doze off. That stops being a concern when he looks up at Tim, still pressed against him, fingers gripping Jason's pelvis. He realises Tim's breath is still fast and shallow, his skin still hot, flushed and thrumming with excitement.

Jason feels his blood pressure start to rise again.

“I— have you— can— want— I—” he tries, time and time again, changing what he intends to say before he even gets one word out. His brain isn’t in *top* shape right now, but he usually can trust in words cooperating a little more than *this* even when he’s tired. Feelings and expressing them to Tim once again prove to be more difficult to deal with than anything before in his life, death included.

He takes a steadying breath before he attempts to speak again.

“Can I suck you off?”

It’s not the most *elegant* way to ask Tim if he’d allow Jason to reciprocate, but it’s the one that his hormone-flooded brain settles on.

Tim’s eyes darken. “*Fuck yes,*” he replies excitedly, almost breathlessly, and hastily pulls away to liberate himself from the harness. Their bodies make a squishy, wet sound when their skin stops being glued together with Jason’s seed trapped between them. In any other moment it would probably be a little weird, a little gross. Right now, neither of them minds.

Tim tosses the harness aside without a second thought, then clambers on top of Jason, pushing him against the headboard and kneeling above his face. His boxers are already soaked, a clear, wet patch on his crotch. Jason’s jaw slacks open a little at the sight.

He grasps Tim by the hips, brings him closer and takes a deep breath in, relishing the moment. The smell is... unique. To call it *pleasant* would seem to compare it to perfumes, flowery and sweet, and that’s not it. Instead, it’s heavy and savoury, exhilarating. It sits in the back of Jason’s throat exactly like he imagined it would.

He swallows loudly and licks his lips, entranced. Tim chuckles at that — less bright and pearly than usually, a little hoarse with arousal instead — then rises off his knees to shuck his last piece of clothing off.

It’s quick and clumsy, guided entirely by the thrill of the moment. Jason still finds it enrapturing. Yesterday he’d call it *a blessing*, something *divine*. He still feels a little anxious when he realises just how much Tim *trusts him* if he’s willing to be this vulnerable and open with him. But he doesn’t feel out of place. Instead it fills him with pride, and love, and joy.

And lust. There’s also a lot of lust.

Without missing a single moment more, Jason leans in to mouth at the exposed skin, adding to its wetness. He rolls his lips across Tim’s cunt, licks along the folds and leaves a trail of saliva in his wake, and Tim struggles to keep quiet. He valiantly tries to suppress his whimpering when Jason kisses the swollen bump of his aroused clit, then gives up completely when Jason gives it a tentative suck. He lets out a loud moan, only barely muffled by the knuckles he shoved into his mouth. The beautiful sound drills itself into Jason’s brain for all eternity while Tim latches onto the headboard with one hand to steady himself. His legs slide into a wider stance and make him slump further down against Jason’s mouth.

Jason takes that as an invitation and truly *dives in*. With his nose flush against Tim’s abdomen, and lips now directly on the soft mound that so far only tempted him through

clothes, he finally experiences Tim like he always wanted — like a wanderer in the desert finding an oasis.

Tim starts to rut absent-mindedly against Jason's lips. His hips make small, aborted little thrusts seemingly without his conscious effort, as if his body is trying to chase the pleasure and fuck itself deeper into Jay's mouth. Attempting to fulfil that desire as much as he can, Jason licks and kisses and sucks earnestly, greedily taking all Tim gives him. He's a little clumsy in his efforts, but makes up for it with enthusiasm, and soon enough Tim's legs start to tremble with effort and pleasure alike. Not long after they give in under him completely as he comes with another stifled, beautiful whine.

Jason savours the moment. Tim's body shivers softly as he rides out the aftershocks, and Jason instinctively matches him with a satisfied rumble, deep from his throat. It's hard not to when he's this content. There's moisture, thick and fragrant and *Tim*, on his lips and all over his chin. He can feel it in his mouth, on his tongue and all the way down in his throat. There's a little on his nose, even, and some slowly drips down over the line of his jaw and down his neck. It makes him feel like he's fully submersed, fully *Tim's*.

He closes his eyes. There's something sublime, something truly magnificent about having his whole face covered by a very physical proof of Tim's pleasure. It's an all-encompassing, intoxicating feeling that brings a sense of calm, washing over him like a wave.

Even if he can't exactly breathe with Tim fully sitting on his face.

Jason wouldn't mind going down drowned in Tim's smell and slick, but luckily, both he and Tim come down from the post-coitus high before he suffocates.

He inhales deeply as Tim lifts off his face, feeling like he's been resurrected again. He takes Tim by the hips and helps him off, then guides him to lay next to him instead.

They don't talk. Jason hasn't been able to verbalise properly for a while now, but apparently even Tim, always composed and witty, loses his grasp on words when fucked out of his mind. Instead of speaking, Tim just smiles again — wide and warm, slightly loopy with exhaustion. Jason replies with the same, and that's all they need before cuddling up together and promptly falling sleep.

He wakes up the next morning and feels... different. The world— no, *he* had shifted, and only now, rested and fully present again, he notices it. (With the way his face is sticky and smells of Tim, it's hard not to.) He's not so pretentious as to say having sex with Tim made him a whole new person. Even Tim can't fuck all the issues out of him. But he sure is a *changed man* now.

It's tempting to call it a *baptism*. Jokingly, at least, now that he *dares* to joke about these things. There were liquids involved, after all, and he came out of it transformed.

Either way, it's been an experience he's not going to forget easily.

His head... his *soul* feels lighter and more optimistic, despite him definitely not losing any weight or any of his grumpy sass. It's like the way spring sunshine always seems brighter than the autumn days. Somehow spring days feel brisk and energetic against the chill of winter still fresh in your mind, while autumn ones come off as cold and gloomy compared to the remnants of summer. And yet, when you check, they're both solidly about 60 degrees.

He likes this new-but-the-same version of himself. It's easier to live like this. But that's no surprise — it's obviously easier to tread water when you don't have the weight of your guilt trying to pull you under. He hopes it will be easier for Tim, too; that he won't have to save Jason from drowning quite as often.

In the coming days, Jason decides to commemorate this *baptism* of his with the occasional *communion* every time Tim lets Jason put his lips to him again. He doesn't compare Tim to God any more these days, but because he drinks *liquid* much akin to sweet wine and takes a body that tastes *divine* into his mouth, it still feels like a sacrament.

As if to illustrate his metamorphosis, his skin produces a new pale spot, right on his chin. Weirdly enough, he's not mad about it, even though it's in such a visible place. Instead of being a cause for panic, it gives him the final push to come out to the world about his condition.

And if the mark is more akin to the stains on the inside of Tim's underwear, bleached out by his juices, than to Jason's vitiligo patches... nobody has to know.

End Notes

1. [*Bella gerant alii, tu felix Austria nube*](#) is a Latin quote translated as “Let others wage war: thou, happy Austria, marry”. It is in reference to Habsburgs’ policy to expand territories via marriages rather than war. In this fic, we could call that *foreshadowing* :D [\[▲\]](#)
2. This beautiful quote is from Julian K. Jarboe on Twitter, later used and popularised by Daniel Mallory Ortberg and Daniel M. Lavery in "Something That May Shock and Discredit You". [\[▲\]](#)

I'd like to think of this story as a stained glass window — painstakingly crafted to become an art piece of complex beauty and abundant colour, hopefully with enough flourishes to distract from the fact that it's a little wonky at the edges.

If you wanna say hi or talk with me, you can find me over on [Tumblr](#) :)

P.S. Would you believe this entire fic came out of Kieran offhandedly mentioning last year in November that she's in the mood to read something with trans Tim pegging Jason gently?

P.P.S. F in the comments for Jason's confessor, that priest really is not paid enough to deal with a zombie vigilante's gay panic and trauma, but he's doing *stellar* if you ask me.

This story is part of the [LLF Comment Project](#), which was created to improve communication between readers and authors. This author invites and appreciates feedback, including:

- Short comments
- Long comments
- Questions
- “<3” as extra kudos
- Reader-reader interaction
- Minor spelling/typo correction

If you'd like to go the extra mile, try answering some of these questions in your comment:

- Did any particular sentence stand out to you? Do you have a favourite phrase from the fic, did you like the way something was worded?
- Did anything make you laugh?
- Has the fic caused an emotional reaction? Touched your heart, made you *feel*?
- Was there any particular scene that you liked?
- Have you noticed any recurring themes or motifs? Any Easter eggs?

This author sees and cherishes all comments, and tries to reply to them all, but may not manage to due to anxiety.

Please [drop by the Archive and comment](#) to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!